

Memory and the Forgotten Source

Phil 101 · Day 6

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Where we are

Recap

Tuesday we asked when a belief is any good, and ran into a famous regress.

- ▶ Reasons need reasons, and there are only three ways that can end.
- ▶ Foundationalists say it stops, at **basic** beliefs.
- ▶ Which leaves the question of what's down there, and that's the question of how many **sources** there are.
- ▶ We mentioned that in the tradition that cared most about this question, the answers ranged from 1 to 6.

Memory

Let's continue our trek through the possible sources of knowledge by looking at something we use *all the time*: memory.

In the reading from Tuesday, Todd Long lists six sources of justification, and memory is the second one, sitting between perception and testimony as though it obviously belongs there.

Is that right?

Is memory a source?

The case against

One of the most detailed discussions we have of memory in South Asian philosophy is by a later writer from the Nyāya school, Udayana. (Probably 10th-11th centuries C.E.)

The older Nyāya texts had listed four ways of acquiring knowledge: perception, inference, analogy, testimony. Note that memory isn't one of these four.

So if you're defending the school, you should have an answer to why memory isn't one of them.

Udayana's answer is a fairly natural one. Memory is **dependent**. Your current knowledge 'via memory' has to have been via something else in the first place.

Does memory reproduce or reconstruct?

Udayana took memory to be a repository, like a library. You put some things in, and hopefully later you can get them back out.

Books in the library don't grow new pages, and memory doesn't produce anything either.

So you can't **learn** by recollection. At most you can **recover** things you previously had.

The other side

Jaina epistemologists didn't accept this, and pressed cases like the following.

i Das

Yesterday, I saw my favourite coffee-mug on my table. This morning, still half asleep, I rummage through cupboards looking for it. Then, I recall, "That coffee-mug was on the table."

Something was learned there, and recollection is what did it. Ten seconds ago you didn't know where to look.

Preservationism and Generativism

Preservationism

Memory can at best **preserve** justification from other sources. It cannot **generate** justification.

Generativism

Memory can **generate** justification. There can be justification that wasn't there before and that memory itself supplies.

Preservationism and Generativism

These are both theories about how memory **justifies**, but they are tied to claims about what memory is.

The preservationist picture goes well with the idea that memory is a **storehouse**, or a **library**.

It accumulates and keeps information that arrived from somewhere else. It doesn't add anything.

This is a very natural picture of memory, basically the default. But it might not be right.

The forgotten source

An iClicker question

I'm going to give everyone full points for this; it isn't a history class. But I want us to think about how we know things.

To the best of your knowledge, who was the third President of the United States?

- A. John Adams
- B. Thomas Jefferson
- C. James Madison
- D. Abraham Lincoln

A second question

Can you remember when and where you learned the answer to that question?

A. Yes

B. No

My gamble

A non-trivial number of you will have answered B both times.

You'll know something, but you won't know how you know it.

This isn't some weird case. We love weird cases in philosophy, and we'll see plenty of them in this course. But this is a *normal* case.

First puzzle for the preservationist view

On this picture, you'd think you would remember who the third President was by remembering learning who the third President was.

We can totally imagine creatures whose minds do work that way.

But that's not how we work.

Second puzzle for the preservationist view

Imagine that you're really good at belief management. You almost never form false beliefs, or irrational beliefs.

But just one day, just once, you did, and came to believe some proposition p .

It was long ago and you've forgotten the experience.

Now someone asks you whether p is true. You consult your memory. You have no recollection of how or why p is stored there, but it is stored there, so you confidently answer yes.

Two views on justification

Is this answer justified?

No. The belief came from a bad method and never picked up any support along the way. Nothing happened in the interim except forgetting, and forgetting doesn't make you *more* justified.

Yes. Your memory is, in general, a reliable thing. A belief you find in there is a fair bet. The bad origin is gone and can't hurt you now.

Two views on justification

The two answers are grading the belief by different things.

One looks **backwards**, at where the belief came from. The other looks at **memory itself**, and how trustworthy it is in general.

Both have a real pull. You don't need a theory of justification to feel it, which is a good sign that it's a live problem rather than a manufactured one.

Preservationism

A useful distinction

Frise makes a helpful distinction here that's easy to miss.

Anti-generativism

Memory cannot **create** justification that wasn't there.

The historical thesis

A belief that enters memory with justification **keeps** it.

Why it matters

The second could be true while the first is false.

That's what you would think if you thought (a) whenever memories are fully preserved, they keep their status, but (b) in cases like the forgotten source, they acquire the justification of typical memory beliefs.

In this case it still seems weird: forgetting basically launders the past mistake. But it might be better than the alternatives.

Memory is not a library

A third question

I'm going to read you a list of words. Just listen; don't write anything down.

I'm going to do some very quick iClicker polls. Again, these aren't for grades; we're just testing something.

I want you to answer these *quickly*, and don't talk to your neighbors.

Was this word on the list?

blanket

A. Yes

B. No

Was this word on the list?

sleep

A. Yes

B. No

Was this word on the list?

coffee

A. Yes

B. No

What just happened

Blanket was on the list. Coffee obviously wasn't.

Sleep was not on the list either. Every word on it was *about* sleep, but I never *said* it.

Let's look at what results we got. (I can't write this up in advance; I don't know the number.)

In the standard version of this experiment, people falsely recall the missing word about as often as they correctly recall the words that really were there. And asked whether they *remember* hearing it or merely find it familiar, most say they remember.

Against the storehouse model

Libraries do not grow books nobody shelved, and books on the shelf do not rewrite themselves because of a question the librarian was asked.

It looks like memory is **reconstructive**, not merely reproductive. It builds something plausible from what it has, and what it has includes patterns and later prompts.

Storehouses and preservation

Now you could say the following, and indeed I find it somewhat tempting.

- ▶ Sure, sure, human memory is a mess, and doesn't look like the library/storehouse model.
- ▶ But it **should**. That's what **good** memory looks like.
- ▶ The function of memory is to preserve, and the fact that it doesn't always perform that function well is psychologically interesting, but doesn't tell us anything about justification.

But if your reason for believing preservationism was that you accepted the storehouse model of how memory actually works, you are left without a good reason.

Going forward

A loose end

Even the safest possible reasoning, deduction, inherits some of these problems.

In a mathematical argument any longer than a few steps, you need to **remember** the earlier lines.

Any concerns about memory should make you nervous about mathematics.

Indeed, Descartes (who we'll come back to a few times) was in no small part motivated by this worry, and produced a very idiosyncratic theory of mathematical knowledge to deal with it. (Roughly, if you're the right kind of Christian you know that God wouldn't let you have false mathematical memories, and that provides the missing support. This convinced approximately no one.)

Tuesday

We'll start talking about testimony, where this time the Nyāya are on the side that says it is a distinctive source.

We'll look at Datta's 1927 paper essentially presenting the argument, dressed up in a way that English readers can follow. And we'll compare his view to the view that testimonial knowledge reduces to perception plus inference.